refuge with a neighbouring prince are very highly thought of; parricide is reserved as the last option in worst-case scenarios. The odd thing in this vicious terrain of royal sagas in which princes are ever ready to stab their fathers in the back is the tenacity of primogeniture. Blood, it seems, was always thicker than water. Kings guard themselves to the hilt against their own sons. But when the time comes, the son inherits.

Did Bindusara send Ashoka to different parts of his empire because he sensed a disaffected son? Ashoka apparently went to Taxila on his father's orders, but whether the emperor sent him there because he wanted to keep a contrary son at bay remains unclear. In any case, for us this seems a good moment to leave Pataliputra and see what Ashoka is likely to have encountered at Taxila if he did indeed go there.

Ashoka would have approached that very distant north-western city somewhat cautiously: it was really very far from Pataliputra, some 2000 km or so across a land, as we shall see, of large rivers and luxuriant forests. At that point in time, Taxila was also said to be a somewhat tense and turbulent place—exactly the sort of frontier location to which the discontented prince was, in Kautilya's opinion, supposed to be transferred.